

Reference Services in the Library

Lesson 3: Basic Reference Interview Techniques

Basic Reference Interview Techniques – Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Open ended vs. closed ended questions** – how each type guides the conversation.
2. **Clarifying the patron's information need** – using probing questions to narrow scope.
3. **Active listening & paraphrasing** – confirming understanding before searching.
4. **Balancing efficiency with thoroughness** – when to switch between question types.
5. **Documenting the request** – recording key details for follow up or future reference.

Summary

The reference interview is a short, focused dialogue that helps librarians uncover exactly what a patron is looking for. The interview begins with **open ended questions** (e.g., "Can you tell me more about what you need?") that invite the patron to describe the context, purpose, and scope of their inquiry. As the conversation progresses, the librarian introduces **closed ended (yes/no or specific) questions** to verify details, eliminate ambiguities, and hone in on the most relevant resources.

Effective reference interviewing also relies on **active listening**—maintaining eye contact, nodding, and paraphrasing the patron's statements ("So you need recent peer reviewed articles on renewable energy policy?"). This confirms that both parties share the same understanding before the search begins.

Throughout the interview, the librarian should be mindful of time, using concise closed questions to keep the interaction efficient while still gathering enough information to provide a high quality answer. Finally, documenting the patron's request (keywords, format, deadline, etc.) ensures that any follow up can be handled quickly and accurately.

Important Points

- **Open ended questions**
 - Start with "What...?", "How...?", "Can you describe...?"
 - Encourage patrons to give background, purpose, and scope.
- **Closed ended questions**
 - Use "Do you need...?", "Is the publication date after...?"
 - Confirm specifics, eliminate irrelevant material, and save time.
- **Probing techniques**
 - Rephrase: "You mentioned you need...; is that correct?"
 - Ask for limits: "Are you looking for a scholarly article, a book, or a website?"
- **Active listening cues**
 - Nod, brief verbal affirmations ("I see," "Got it").

- Summarize the request before searching.
 - **Efficiency tip**
- Begin broadly, then narrow with closed questions once the general need is clear.
 - **Documentation**
- Write down key terms, format, audience, deadline, and any access restrictions.

Examples

Example 1 – Academic Research Query

Patron: “I need help with a paper.”

| Step | Question Type | Sample Question | Why it works |

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|---|--------------|--|---|
| 1 | Open ended | “What is the topic of your paper?” | Gets the subject area and context. |
| 2 | Open ended | “What kind of sources does your instructor prefer?” | Reveals format (journal article, book, etc.). |
| 3 | Closed ended | “Do you need sources published after 2018?” | Sets a date range, narrowing results. |
| 4 | Closed ended | “Is a peer reviewed source required?” | Confirms quality level. |
| 5 | Paraphrase | “So you need recent, peer reviewed journal articles on climate change mitigation for a 10 page undergraduate paper, due next Friday. Is that right?” | Verifies understanding before searching. |

Example 2 – General Information Request

Patron: “I’m looking for information on local hiking trails.”

| Step | Question Type | Sample Question | Why it works |

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|---|--------------|---|---|
| 1 | Open ended | “Can you tell me more about the type of trails you’re interested in?” | Lets patron mention length, difficulty, location. |
| 2 | Closed ended | “Do you need printable maps?” | Determines format. |
| 3 | Closed ended | “Are you looking for trails within 20 miles of the city?” | Sets geographic limit. |
| 4 | Paraphrase | “You’d like printable maps of easy to moderate trails within 20 /mi of downtown, plus any recent trail condition updates. Correct?” | Confirms details before providing resources. |

Quick Review

1. **What is the primary purpose of starting a reference interview with an open ended question?**
2. **Give two examples of closed ended questions you might ask to narrow a patron’s request for scholarly articles.**
3. **Why is paraphrasing the patron’s request an essential step before beginning the search?**
4. **List three active listening cues you can use during the interview.**
5. **What key pieces of information should you document from the interview?**

Further Reading

- **“The Reference Interview: A Review of the Literature”** – A comprehensive overview of interview models.

- ****Information-Seeking Behaviors in Academic Libraries**** – Studies on patron expectations and question types.
- ****Active Listening in Library Services**** – Techniques for improving comprehension and patron satisfaction.
- ****Developing a Reference Interview Checklist**** – Practical tools for consistent documentation.

Use these notes to practice shifting smoothly between open and closed questions, and remember that confirming understanding is as important as gathering the information itself.

